Chapter 11 — Group 11
ONLY YOU CONTROL WHAT YOU DO

[Instructions: Read this chapter prior to coming to your next group. Answer the questions before coming to group. ***You will share your responses to the questions in group.***]

This small workbook has repeatedly stated that each of us only controls ourselves and our behavior. And some people don't do a very good job at that. So, how do you feel about your relationships now? Do you feel your life and your relationships are out of your control? Do you have some genuine acceptance about what you can and cannot control? Do you feel better about yourself?

Untangling yourself from problem relationships is a way of gaining freedom to become yourself. Sometimes people are so wrapped up in others' problems that they lose themselves. They become a false person — trapped by misguided attempts to control. Once you understand how you have become tangled in others' feelings and behavior, you can become free to explore your own abilities and desires. Hopefully, you have more than begun that process and are well on your way to real happiness and meaning in your life.

The purpose of this program has not been to have you terminate your problem relationships. However, it may be that ending a relationship is the right thing to do — and the only good choice. But our bigger purpose was to have you take control of yourself and to become realistic about how much you can control others. Your happiness rests on your shoulders. It is foolish to place your happiness and purpose in life in another person's hands.

1. Good Times & Bad Times

Begin this exercise by listing the 5 best times you have ever had with other people. Think about all of your life and write something about each experience below.

1. Chocolatefest NW - people there are friendly and excited about their chocolate.
2. Boy Scout Canoe trip to Current River - a nice escape from the situation I grew up with.
3. Thanksgiving with my son 2016 (he was 2) - good food and time with my son.
4. Inpatient Rehab 2010 - isolation and no worries about the "outside".
5. Pen Club - everyone is just there to have fun.

Now, list the 5 worst times you have ever had with other people. Think about all of your life and write something about each experience below.

1. There was a DUI I got with people in the car. Most of the times I drank around other people I hated apologizing the next day.
2. I had a bad birthday that was supposed to be "fun", but I didn't like picking things with weird names from the menu, and eating food with unmatched utensils.
3. My parents separation kind of sucked. That involved being around people. I missed my mom, and could only see her on odd weekends.
4. Losing my son has sucked a lot.
5. Court is always unpleasant when I'm in it - plaintiff or not.

In looking at your 5 good times, how much control did you have? Did you cause the experience? Did you have a good, acceptant attitude? What was it that made each good time so good? Answer these questions below. Each good time had a different reason. I didn't really have any control of a situation once I was there, there's no control when others are joining in the situation.

In looking at your 5 bad times, how much control did you have? Did you cause the experience? Did you have a negative attitude? What was it that made each bad time so bad? Answer these questions below. In group, you will be asked to answer a few questions about what you wrote.

I caused 3 of them. The others were situations that were a lot of change that I was unhappy about.

2. Where Do You Think You Are Right Now?

Before ending this chapter, the next to last in the program, you need to take a good look at yourself and your relationships. ***You do not have to share everything*** you write here in group.

Do you believe you have made any progress in problem relationships since you entered this program?

I question all of my relationships and the status of them, now. I don't take any of my relationships for granted and pay attention to my behavior to ~~make sure that my part of it is as health as I can make it. I am learning more about~~ relationships so I can continue to make them healthy.

Is there something else can you do to work on your problem relationships?

I don't have much that I can do in any 'problem' relationships. I can't see my son or my ex-wife so nothing can help with those, and I don't ~~tend to keep people around if the relationship feels uncomfortable. Family-wise, my biggest problem in the family~~ isn't around anymore, and the rest of us are doing our best to get by and be supportive.

Look back at the things you checked in Chapter 10 (page 24). Which of those issues do you believe you need to work on? In Chapter 10, I selected "take things personally", and I do need to make sure I'm keeping an eye on that. In most cases, I need to be open to constructive criticism and learn how to change and adapt in a healthy way rather than get offended and bulldoze through something that isn't working for the group.

Do you need to ask the group or your facilitator to point you in the direction of more help?

Not right now, I still have the rest of the program to talk things out in.

Is there anything you want to say to the facilitator? Nope, keep facilitatin'!

Do you want to meet individually with the group facilitator? We have before and we may again.

If you have filled out this chapter before group and successfully shared your responses in group, you will be asked to move on to the next chapter. Remember that you do not have to share all of the things you wrote in the last section of this chapter.